

MEDIA AND GOVERNMENT CENSORSHIP: EVIDENCE FROM MEXICO

Eduardo Zago¹

¹PhD Student NYU Politics

ROADMAP

- ▶ **RQ1: How does the government react to media outlets being critic of it?**
- ▶ **Hypothesis: Uses advertising spending to reward compliant outlets and punish critical ones. (Emp. Strategy)**
- ▶ Due to comments received, this presentation I will try to convince you of a few things:
 1. Why this is important in general (lit. review).
 2. Why this is particularly relevant in the Mexican context (context)
 3. Why the lottery assignment to the first row might be a good instrument.

LITERATURE REVIEW

- ▶ Even in the absence of outright censorship, the government still has techniques to silence critics ([Besley and Prat, 2006](#); [Guriev and Treisman, 2020](#))
- ▶ Some ways in which government can censor in democracies:
 1. Bribery: Montesinos in Peru ([Mcmillan and Zoido, 2004](#))
 2. De-legitimization: South Korea *giraegi* and US (Trump) ([Shin, Kim and Joo, 2021](#); [Carlson, Robinson and Lewis, 2021](#)).
 3. Restriction of source access: Kisha clubs in Japan ([Kuga, 2016](#)).
 4. Government advertising in Argentina correlated with favorable coverage ([Di Tella and Franceschelli, 2011](#))
- ▶ To the best of my knowledge, no causal evidence on any of these.

MEXICAN CONTEXT

- ▶ Historical evidence of the use of advertising spending for favorable coverage:

“Pay for them to beat up on me? Gentlemen, I think not!”

— President Lopez Portillo (1982) while announcing the withdrawal of advertising spending to independent media ([Rafael, 1993](#)).

- ▶ More recently, anecdotal evidence from the NYT that PRI used these resources again (2012-2018):

“With its enormous advertising budget, the Mexican government controls the media.”

— On PRI 2012-2018 government ([Ahmed, 2017](#)).



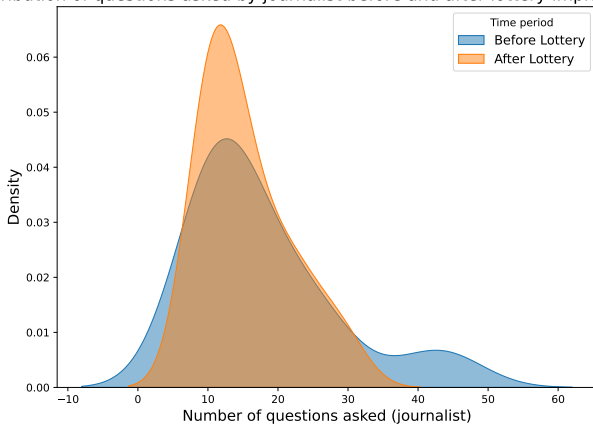
DESCRIPTIVE STATISTICS

- ▶ From initial text analysis of the morning press conferences I retrieved some useful statistics.
- ▶ I retrieved the name of the journalists and media outlets they represented using GPT.
- ▶ From April 2021 to April 2023, 556 different journalists asked questions, 496 different outlets (after deduplication).¹
- ▶ Looked at 10 press conferences at random over this period of time, and documented how many times they asked questions from the first (71%), second (20%), third (4.5%) and fourth (4.5%) row.
- ▶ Finally, checked the distributions of questions asked by journalist and media outlets before and after the lottery was implemented

¹The lottery was implemented on April 2022

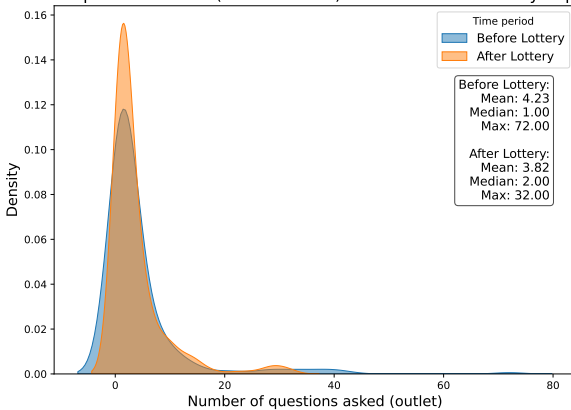
LOTTERY

Distribution of questions asked by journalist before and after lottery implementation



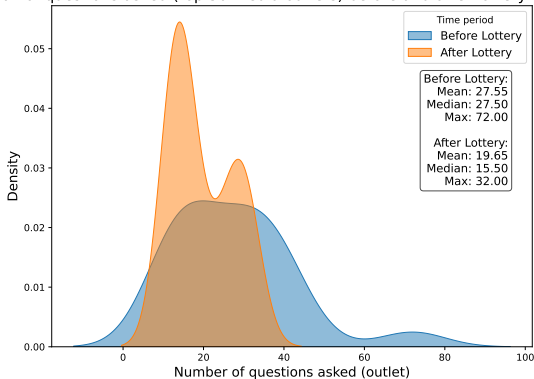
LOTTERY

Distribution of questions asked (media outlets) before and after lottery implementation



LOTTERY

Distribution of questions asked (top 30 media outlets) before and after lottery implementation



LOTTERY

TABLE: Top 10 Outlets that Asked the Most Questions

Outlet (Before)	Questions (Before)	Outlet (After)	Questions (After)
Grupo Healy	72	Grupo Healy	32
A Tiempo TV	42	La Crónica	31
Tabasco Hoy	40	Frontera	30
Campeche Hoy	39	Contralínea	29
Quintana Roo Hoy ²	37	SDP Noticias	28
Frontera	35	Proceso ³	28
diario Basta ⁴	33	Canal 11	25
La Crónica	32	El Financiero ⁵	22
Contralínea	29	Noticiero en Redes.	18
Imagen del Golfo	28	Tabasco Hoy	16

² Widely considered 'southern friendly outlets' of the government ([Animal Político](#))

³ AMLO of Proceso: '*Conservative journalism, serving corrupt minorities, either directly or indirectly, consciously or unconsciously.*'

⁴ Diario Basta CEO: 'Thanks to my friend and fellow countryman, President López Obrador, for his support throughout his administration to @diariobasta and @grupocanton. Love is repaid with love.'

⁵ AMLO to a Financiero journalist: '*I don't want to get involved in that. Why should I give a story to your newspaper if you're against us?*'

REFERENCES

- Ahmed, Azam. 2017. "Con su enorme presupuesto de publicidad, el gobierno mexicano controla los medios de comunicación." *New York Times* .
URL: <https://www.nytimes.com/es/2017/12/25/espanol/con-su-enorme-presupuesto-de-publicidad-el-gobierno-mexicano-controla-los-medios-de-comunicacion-pri-pena-nieto.html>
- Besley, Timothy and Andrea Prat. 2006. "Handcuffs for the Grabbing Hand? Media Capture and Government Accountability." *American Economic Review* 96(3):720–736.
- Carlson, Matt, Sue Robinson and Seth C. Lewis. 2021. The Trump Presidency: Four Years of Battling and Belittling the Press. In *News After Trump: Journalism's Crisis of Relevance in a Changed Media Culture*. Oxford University Press.
- Di Tella, Rafael and Ignacio Franceschelli. 2011. "Government Advertising and Media Coverage of Corruption Scandals." *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics* 3(4):119–51.
- Gurie, Sergei and Daniel Treisman. 2020. "A theory of informational autocracy." *Journal of Public Economics* 186:104158.
- Kuga, Kimiko. 2016. "Kisha clubs in Japan: an impregnable fortress of information." *Free Speech Debate* .
URL: <https://freespeechdebate.com/discuss/an-impregnable-fortress-of-information/>
- Mcmillan, John and Pablo Zoido. 2004. "How to Subvert Democracy: Montesinos in Peru." *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 18(4):69–92.
- Rafael, Rodríguez. 1993. "Prensa vendida: los periodistas y los presidentes, 40 años de relaciones." *Grijalbo* .
- Shin, Wooyeol, Changwook Kim and Jaewon Joo. 2021. "Hating journalism: Anti-press discourse and negative emotions toward journalism in Korea." *Journalism* 22(5):1239–1255.

RESEARCH DESIGN RQ1

- ▶ Estimate the impact of critical coverage on government advertising spending by media outlet. ([Intro](#))
- ▶ OLS probably biased due to time-based endogeneity and unobserved confounding factors related to criticism level and advertising allocation.
- ▶ **Instrumental Variable (IV) Approach:** Use lottery assignment to the first, second or third row at morning press conferences as an instrument for $NumCr_{i,t}$.
- ▶ First Stage Equation:

$$NumCr_{i,t} = \theta_0 + \theta_1 FirstRow_{i,t} + \mathbf{X}'_{i,t}\gamma + \epsilon_{i,t}$$